

Diploma in Leadership & Management

Team building tools



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Lesson outcomes

The student will be able to understand the fundamentals of both virtual and in-person team building. The student will have a greater understanding of the importance of team building, how to set up team building events. The students will also be exposed to good team building practices and examples.

Introduction

Team building is the tool used by managers and leaders to bring their individual team members together. By hosting effective team building events, you are encouraging employees to connect, collaborate and build better relationships. Team building is a buzz word used a lot in business but few team building events or approaches actually make an impact. In order to have effective team building events and activities, you need to know both the practical and theoretical side of team building. “Team building is the process of turning a group of individual contributing employees into a cohesive team—a group of people organized to work together to meet the needs of their customers by accomplishing their purpose and goals..” (Thebalancecareers)

Key reading materials:

- <https://www.thebalancecareers.com/what-is-team-building-1918270>
- <https://www.managementstudyguide.com/team-building.htm>
- <https://www.managementstudyguide.com/team-building-tips.htm>
- https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=H0_yKBitO8M



Psychological safety insights:

According to (Terego, n.d.) we see the following best practices when it comes to team building. Please note that these are direct insights from the source. Here we are going to look at the difference between a team and a committee and then the best practices all managers and leaders should take into account when thinking of team building.

Committee Vs. Team

A Team:

- A Team is united around a clear goal.
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- A Team usually has shared or rotating leadership.
- A Team is structured to work together to achieve that goal.
- A Team shares responsibility for achieving that goal.
- A Team member depends on the other members.
- A Team member builds relationships with other members.
- A Team member is empowered to contribute their skills and experience.
- A Team demands a consensus decision.
- A Team measures itself by the goals it sets for itself.

A Committee:

- A Committee is by nature administrative in nature.
- A Committee usually has a strong leader.
- A Committee is usually formed to decide if something needs to be done.
- A Committee usually has an oversight responsibility.
- A Committee normally assigns tasks to others outside the committee and only oversees and measures their effectiveness.

The fundamentals of team building that all managers and leaders should know:

1. The team's goal must be clearly identified and agreed.
2. The resources to achieve the goal must be identified and agreed.
3. The right people must be involved.
4. The recommended action must be practical and appropriate.
5. The right resources must be used.
6. The larger context and implications must be considered.
7. The time scale agreed upon must be reasonable.
8. The results must be used as a basis for further improvement.

Best practices when it comes to team building

- Teamwork is mutual inquiry requiring mutual respect.
- Listening is as important as talking. Both are interpersonal skills.
- Thinking in a team is difficult without rules of conduct.
- Teamwork is a non-competitive quest to make meaning.
- Teamwork is not a debate with winners and losers.
- Mutual inquiry is an iterative process.

Let us have an analytical look at each one of them:

1. Mutual respect.
 2. Mutual inquiry with mutual respect is more likely to succeed. So, rules of conduct must be in place. Respectful listening and discussion is much more productive. Don't interrupt, don't attack a person question their ideas. Be courteous.
 3. Listening and talking.
 4. Mindful deliberate listening is not only courteous it helps mutual understanding and avoids misunderstandings. It is one half of our interpersonal skill. The other half is talking, and talking can either be a minefield or a rich source of discourse. It depends on how well we conduct a collaborative thinking exercise.
 5. Thinking.
 6. Thinking, either as an individual or collective effort, is why the team has come together since the team's only purpose is to solve a problem, and the only way to solve problems is through thinking, and the only way to think is in questions, and that is best achieved by a step-by-step process.
 7. A quest for meaning.
 8. The only reason for a team to exist is to mutually make sense of something that is not making sense, and has so far eluded individual efforts at making sense or meaning.
 9. Winners and losers.
 10. A team focused on a common goal is not a debate between members. The team wins collectively or fails together.
 11. Teamwork is an iterative process.
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12. The chances that a team will come up with the right solution to the right problem at its first attempt are not good. Patience is required. Also required is the ability to learn from previous iterations. What your team should be doing is collectively building mental models of a suggested solutions and then interrogating the model until they are happy that it works.

Team building pitfalls:



According to (Clemmer, n.d.) here are some common pitfalls that managers and leaders need to identify and overcome.

Understanding Team Bonding

While team building is all about bringing together employees towards a common goal, team bonding is about building new teams and strengthening established working relationships through fun outings and organized activities.

Team bonding events include sports and beach sports tournaments, tailgate games and competitions, and themed activity based events like Pumpkin Carving Contests, Halloween or Holiday Kooky Cookie Cook Offs, or other organized activities. These team bonding events are less based on achieving a certain goal and more focused toward having a good time together away from work. The idea is to set up an environment that may lead team members to start casual conversations with each other. Team bonding events can be big or small and it's always a good idea to plan a few different outings, onsite team bondings, and/or other recognitions throughout the year.

A few examples of fun team bonding events include cornhole tournament and fast pitch contest tailgate before a Padres game. One popular activity is a scavenger hunt through historic landmarks across San Diego's Balboa Park. Or team bonding could be as simple as an onsite ice cream social, Friday happy hour, bbq catering in the office parking lot, or a fun holiday cookie decorating contest, just to name a few.

To get the most out of your event and to maximize participation always make sure delicious food, fun activities and/or entertainment are provided. Your outgoing members will get to be in the limelight while spectator team members will enjoy watching, laughing and cheering for their team members, which is what team bonding is all about.

Common pitfalls to avoid:



Not listening to team suggestions

Remember, any team bonding and team building activities should be centered on your team's interests. Listen to their suggestions and structure your event around their interests if possible. If done right, this could lead to maximum participation levels across the team.

Not Knowing Your Group's Abilities

Every person has varying levels of skill and ability. Getting to know their strengths and weaknesses will help you choose activities that complement their particular skill set. More importantly, it ensures that no one is left out!

Not Having a Clear Set of Goals

It is important to create a goal roadmap for each activity to ensure your team reaches its full potential. Not having a clear goal in mind may end up jeopardizing your event. Start by determining the primary objectives of the event. It also helps to define a few metrics to measure the success of each event.

Having a Cluster of Cliques

Breaking up interoffice cliques when forming teams for activities will help to make the most of the team building experience. This will both allow for more group interaction and help to eliminate side conversations making easier for all involved to pay attention to game instructions.

Not Having Multiple Events Throughout the Year

It is recommended to host a couple of team building and/or team bonding events and activities throughout the year. This ensures your team is keyed in on the importance of teamwork, communication, and cooperation throughout the year. A one-off event once a year would do little to hammer home the idea of employee appreciation, teamwork, and company loyalty.

Team building ideas: Virtual team building ideas



Please note that these virtual team building ideas are supplied by (Sussman, n.d.)

Tiny campfire:

tiny campfire runs virtual campfires for remote teams. The experience includes haunted historic ghost stories, icebreakers, little competitions and even a real s'more making experience. It's fun, wildly smart, and probably the best damn online camping experience in the world. No mosquito repellent needed.

Before your event, tiny campfire sends each person on your team a small package with materials like s'more ingredients, a tealight candle, and matches. Receiving a package in the mail is fun and your people will appreciate it. This event creates unique shared memories, good vibes and strong virtual employee engagement.

Tea vs Coffee:

Tea vs Coffee facilitates an exotic coffee and tea tasting experience with real beverages. A week or so before your event, your employees receive a mix of four specialty teas, coffees and infusions in the mail. Each envelope is marked as "do not open" to save the big surprise for the event.

On tasting day, your team logs into a virtual video-cafe, where the friendly barista will share stories, run virtual team building games, and lead a tasting ceremony. The event is fun, educational, and global minded.

War of the Wizards:

War of the Wizards is one of the most unique and engaging virtual team building activities in the world. The game is a live, facilitated event that goes for 90 minutes and includes mechanics of RPG games, escape rooms, puzzle solving, storytelling and world building.

Basically, a group of wizards have been at war for eons, and none of them quite remember why. You and your colleagues becomes the wizards' minions; telling stories, solving puzzles and completing challenges to earn "sparkle points", cast spells and do whatever it takes to bring a peaceful resolution to the war. This game is smart, fun, wildly different and perfect for remote teams.

Important: You don't need to be an RPG expert to enjoy War of the Wizards; the game format is accessible for all skill levels and interests.

Spreadsheet Pixel Art:

You are probably familiar with Google Sheets, but maybe not as a tool for remote team building.

If you are a nerd like me then you likely enjoy developing complicated spreadsheet formulas and graphs. If you are both a nerd and an artist, then you will love doing Spreadsheet Pixel Art.

Spreadsheet Pixel Art is when you add a little code to automatically replace numbers with a color fill for that cell. You can then use these colors to “paint the numbers” and create pictures of nearly anything.

Pro tip: For virtual team bonding with a little competitive spirit we recommend introducing this activity as a competition.

Online Team Building Bingo:

Online Team Building Bingo is a fun and familiar game, which makes it a quick, easy and free way to get started with virtual team building.

You start with a bingo board that has a number of action items or accomplishments on it. For example, when you hear someone say “sorry, I was on mute!” you can mark that spot off on your board, and similar for “wearing pajama bottoms to a video meeting.”

Quarterly Christmas:

Every December 26th, Carly starts counting down for Christmas. This countdown doesn't have to be a long wait, and instead you can run Quarterly Christmas or Quarterly Care Package for your team.

Basically, once every few months you surprise your team members with a package in the mail. Quarterly Christmas is effective because getting a surprise package is like a little burst of sunshine on an otherwise cloudy day.

Examples of packages you can send include tech gadgets, coffee and tea samplers, chocolate and wine, and gift cards. If your remote workers have furry friends then you can send pet toys as well.

We recommend a budget of about \$25 per person per quarter, plus shipping.

Team building ideas: In-person team building



As provided by (Hansen, n.d.)

Game of Possibilities

Time: 5-6 minutes

Number of Participants: One or multiple small groups

Tools Needed: Any random objects

Rules: This is a great 5-minute team building game. Give an object to one person in each group. One at a time, someone has to go up in front of the group and demonstrate a use for that object. The rest of the team must guess what the player is demonstrating. The demonstrator cannot speak, and demonstrations must be original, possibly wacky, ideas.

Objective: This team building exercise inspires creativity and individual innovation.

Winner/Loser

Time: 5-6 minutes

Number of Participants: Two or more people

Tools Needed: None

Rules: Partner A shares something negative that happened in their life with Partner B. It can be a personal or work-related memory, but it has to be true. Then Partner A discusses the same experience again, but focuses only on the positive aspects. Partner B helps explore the silver lining of the bad experience. Afterward, they switch roles.

Objective: Participants discover how to reframe negative situations into learning experiences together.

Purpose Mingle

Time: 1 - 2 minutes

Number of Participants: Any

Tools Needed: None

Rules: This one is for those of you looking for a great indoor team building game that won't take up much time. Before a

meeting, have each individual walk around and share what they hope to contribute to the meeting with as many people as possible. If you want, offer a prize for the person who shares with the most people, and another for the person who successfully contributes what they shared.

Objective: Improves meeting productivity and makes attendees think about how they're going to contribute, rather than just what they hope to get out of the meeting.

Outdoor Team Building Games

Scavenger Hunt

Time: > 1 hour

Number of Participants: Two or more small groups

Tools Needed: Pen and Paper

Rules: Break the group into teams of two or more. Make a list of goofy tasks for each team to do as a group. Tasks can include taking a selfie with a stranger, taking a picture of a building or object around the office, etc. Give the list to each team, along with a deadline by which they must complete all tasks. Whoever completes the most tasks the quickest, wins! (You can even create your own point system according to task difficulty if you want!)

Objective: Great team bonding exercise that helps break up office cliques by encouraging people to work with colleagues from other teams, departments, or just social circles.

**Fun Fact: At Wrike, we hosted our own scavenger hunt using our tool to track the tasks. Check out how we used Wrike for fun!*

Human Knot

Time: 15 - 30 minutes

Number of Participants: 8 - 20 people

Tools Needed: None

Rules: Have everyone stand in a circle facing each other, shoulder to shoulder. Instruct everyone to put their right hand out and grab a random hand of someone across from them. Then, tell them to put their left hand out and grab another random hand from a different person across the circle. Within a set time limit, the group needs to untangle the knot of arms without releasing their hands. If the group is too large, make multiple smaller circles and have the separate groups compete.

Objective: This game for team building relies heavily on good communication and teamwork. It also results in a lot of great stories for the water cooler chat in the workplace.

References

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